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Brand familiarity: its effects on satisfaction evaluations

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to examine the moderating effects of brand familiarity on satisfaction evaluations and behavioral intentions.

Design/methodology/approach – A longitudinal survey involving pre-purchase measures and post-purchase measures was conducted with consumers in a restaurant setting. The hypotheses were assessed through LISREL methodology.

Findings – The results showed that there are some similarities and differences among customers with different levels of brand familiarity regarding satisfaction formation and behavioral intentions.

Research limitations/implications – A self-reported item was used to measure brand familiarity. Although there was some evidence to support that the measure captured what it was intended to measure, it would be desirable to develop a multi-item scale for this construct. There is also a need to extend the findings to other service industries.

Practical implications – Marketers should familiarize customers with a service while capturing opportunities to create a positive experience to gain customers' future purchases.

Originality/value – The study offers some insights into the effects of brand familiarity on satisfaction evaluations and behavioral intentions. It is particularly relevant for marketing services that are high in experience qualities.

Keywords Brand awareness, Customer satisfaction

Paper type Research paper

An executive summary for managers can be found at the end of this article.

Introduction

Customer satisfaction continues to draw interest and attention among academics and practitioners alike since it is a necessary precondition to succeed in highly competitive markets. The most prominent conceptual model that explains the customer satisfaction formation process is the expectancy-disconfirmation model. Despite much effort having been devoted to understanding the satisfaction formation process, the results of various studies have been inconsistent. Johnson and Fornell (1991) suggest that differences found in studies of the effects of expectations, disconfirmation and perceptions of performance on satisfaction may be attributable to individual differences and product/service category differences. Churchill and Surprenant (1982) suggest that the process of satisfaction formation may vary for different types of products/services.

While familiarity has been used to explain the differences in information acquisition and choice behavior, little has been studied of its effects on post-purchase evaluations. Do customers who are familiar with a brand evaluate their satisfaction with the brand's performance in a similar manner

as customers who are not familiar with the brand? This is an intriguing issue, particularly for services that are high in experience qualities in which customers can only evaluate during consumption. Customers are likely to have less well-formed expectations of its performance since prior beliefs about a brand's performance are only verifiable through consumption experience (Hoch and Deighton, 1989). It is expected that low familiarity customers would exert a greater cognitive effort in evaluating a brand's performance, and that they are likely to experience some disconfirmation of their expectations. On the other hand, high familiarity customers may require less cognitive effort in evaluating a brand's performance due to the fact that they have already established some rules and have a better knowledge structure (Alba and Hutchinson, 1987). Moreover, if high familiarity customers continue to make repeat purchases in a competitive market, they presumably have some positive evaluations of the brand (Johnson and Fornell, 1991). It is reasonable to predict that the relationship between customer satisfaction and repeat purchase is stronger for high familiarity customers than for low familiarity customers.

There is little research available on the effects of brand familiarity on post-purchase evaluations. The objective of this study is to examine the moderating effects of brand familiarity on satisfaction and behavioral intentions, specifically repurchase and recommendation intentions. The study extends the relationship between satisfaction and behavioral intentions to include post-consumption expectations. These

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are expectations updated through consumption experience, and should be instrumental in predicting repeat purchases. Review of the literature has found that only Yi and La's (2004) research has considered the effects of post-consumption expectations on repeat purchase behavior.

In the next section, a review of the literature on customer satisfaction and familiarity is presented, followed by a discussion of the development of the research framework and hypotheses. The methodology of the study is then described, and the analysis and results are presented. Lastly, the managerial implications of the results are discussed and some suggestions for future research are offered.

Literature review

Customer satisfaction

Customer satisfaction is defined as an emotional state that occurs in response to the evaluation of a service (Cadotte *et al.*, 1987; Westbrook, 1981). Oliver (1980) considers that the evaluative process involves disconfirmed expectations and customers' expectations about a service. This process is referred to as expectancy disconfirmation in the satisfaction literature. Oliver (1980) posited expectations as adapted standards which provide a frame of reference for customers' evaluative judgments. If there is a disparity between expectations and perceptions of performance, disconfirmation occurs, which in turn may affect the level of satisfaction. Churchill and Surprenant (1982) were among the first to extend this model to include a direct effect of perceived performance on satisfaction. Other studies have also extended the model to include post-purchase behavioral intentions (Gupta and Stewart, 1996; Yoon and Kim, 2000). Recent research has included involvement as a moderator of satisfaction evaluations (Bolfing and Woodruff, 1988; Spreng and Sonmez, 2000, 2001).

Brand familiarity

Alba and Hutchison (1987) defined familiarity as the number of product-related/service-related experiences that have been accumulated by the consumer. These related experiences include direct and indirect experiences such as advertising exposures, interactions with salespersons, word of mouth communications, trial and consumption. Johnson and Russo (1984) viewed familiarity as being synonymous with knowledge. Johnson and Kellaris (1988) considered experience contributing to familiarity. Review of the literature indicates that knowledge, experience and familiarity are closely related. Following Alba and Hutchison's (1987) definition, brand familiarity is defined as the accumulated related experiences that customers have had with a brand.

Studies have shown that familiarity influences consumers' decision-making process (Bettman and Park, 1980; Park and Lessig, 1981), the relationship between price and quality (Johnson and Kellaris, 1988), and advertising effectiveness (Campbell and Keller, 2003). Söderlund (2002) showed that satisfaction and behavioral intentions are different between high and low familiarity customers in extreme conditions that is, either high performance or low performance, in an experimental setting. However, the effects of familiarity on the evaluation process of satisfaction and the relationship between satisfaction and behavioral intentions have not been explored.

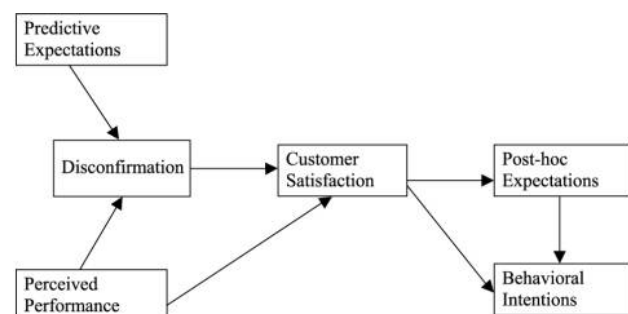
Johnson and Fornell (1991) expect that experience has an effect on satisfaction evaluations. From a dynamic perspective, they argue that as experience increases, not only expectations become entrenched, but they may also coincide with perceived performance, and less likely result in disconfirmation. This may suggest that satisfaction is not influenced by disconfirmation but accumulated experience. Zajonc and Markus (1982) suggest that familiarity may lead to positive evaluations of a service or object. When confronted with a familiar service/brand, the consumer may feel a glow of warmth and intimacy.

Research framework and hypotheses

The research framework for this study expands the expectancy-disconfirmation model by incorporating brand familiarity as a moderator of satisfaction evaluations and behavioral intentions. Moreover, post-consumption expectations are included in the model as they are expected to play an important role in influencing post-purchase behavior. Previous studies have devoted considerable effort to understanding the relationship between satisfaction and loyalty, but incorporation of the *post-hoc* expectations to predict repurchase and recommendation behavior is scarce (Yi and La, 2004).

Expectations are a dynamic phenomenon as they are continuously updated based on new information. There is some empirical support for the effect of experience on expectations (Dorsch *et al.*, 2000; Johnson and Mathews, 1997; Tam, 2005; Yi and La, 2004). Anderson and Sullivan (1993) suggest that disconfirmation influences customer satisfaction, and in turn may lead to an adjustment of expectations toward the next purchase. In line with this, Rust and Oliver (2000) indicated that delighting customers by delivering a service beyond the normal expected range would heighten repurchase expectations and make it more difficult to satisfy the customers in the future. This supports the notion that expectations are dynamic, that is, they change based on new information acquired from service experience, and these updated expectations will influence customers' intentions regarding repurchase and recommendation to others. Based on this discussion and consistent with prior research by Yi and La (2004), it is posited that satisfaction will influence *post-hoc* expectations, which in turn will influence behavioral intentions. Figure 1 presents the research framework for this study.

Figure 1 Framework for customer satisfaction and behavioral intentions



Effects of brand familiarity on satisfaction formation process

Expectations influence consumers' choices of brand or type of service (Spreng *et al.*, 1993). In a normal purchase situation, if customers anticipate that brand A's performance is better than that of other brands, then they will choose and consume brand A, on the assumption that all other factors are equal. However, since services are intangible, customers who are not familiar with a brand are less likely to accurately anticipate the level of services to be received. In some cases, their expectations may be inflated by their wishes to get the best out of the deal or by exaggerated marketing practice. Contrary to this, Kopalle and Lehmann (2001) drew on cognitive dissonance theory, arguing that customers may understate expectations in order to avoid disappointment or to justify purchase decision. There is empirical evidence to show that expectations have a negative effect on disconfirmation (Cadotte *et al.*, 1987; Patterson, 1993; Spreng *et al.*, 1996). With little knowledge or experience, it is expected that there is high uncertainty about the prediction of outcome among low familiarity customers. Consequently, they are more likely to result in high disconfirmation than moderate and high familiarity customers.

Perceived performance has a positive effect on disconfirmation, which in turn influences satisfaction (Montfort *et al.*, 2000; Patterson *et al.*, 1997). The higher a performance, the more likely that customers' expectations will be exceeded, thus resulting in positive disconfirmation, and leading to satisfaction. On the other hand, the lower a performance, the less likely that customers' expectations will be met, thus resulting in negative disconfirmation, and leading to dissatisfaction. Low familiarity customers are likely to rely on perceptions of performance during consumption to verify prior beliefs, and subsequently use disconfirmation to evaluate satisfaction. When customers are experiencing an unfamiliar brand, they are more likely to have the goal of learning about and forming an accurate impression of the brand (Campbell and Keller, 2003). On the other hand, high familiarity customers with some established rules and knowledge structure may be less motivated to learn from consumption experience (Hoch and Deighton, 1989). Disconfirming evidence in one particular instance may be irrelevant to the validity of a rule (Hoch, 1984). It is expected that the effect of perceived performance on disconfirmation, and the effect of disconfirmation on satisfaction are stronger for low familiarity customers than for high familiarity customers.

Perceived performance has a positive effect on satisfaction. This effect has been found in a number of studies, despite different types of products/services investigated and different customer involvement (Churchill and Surprenant, 1982; Gupta and Stewart, 1996; Liljander and Strandvik, 1993; Spreng and Sonmez, 2000, 2001). Familiarity may have a positive effect on evaluations of a service (Zajonc and Markus, 1982). An individual develops stronger associations to a stimulus as exposure increases. If previous encounters are positive, one additional encounter is likely to produce increased liking. On the other hand, if previous encounters are negative, one additional encounter is likely to produce increased disliking (Söderlund, 2002). These associations

tend to be of similar valence, that is, a positively evaluated stimulus produces positive associations, and a negatively evaluated stimulus produces negative associations (Grush, 1976). This leads us to suggest that the effect of perceived performance on satisfaction is stronger for high and moderate familiarity customers than for low familiarity customers. Based on the preceding discussions, the following hypotheses are proposed:

- H1. The effect of expectations on disconfirmation differs among high, moderate and low familiarity customers
- H2. The effect of perceived performance on disconfirmation differs among high, moderate and low familiarity customers
- H3. The effect of disconfirmation on satisfaction differs among high, moderate and low familiarity customers
- H4. The effect of perceived performance on satisfaction differs among high, moderate and low familiarity customers

Effects of brand familiarity on behavioral intentions

In a competitive market, consumers generally do not continue to purchase a brand toward which they are ambivalent or of which they hold negative evaluations (Johnson and Fornell, 1991). If a customer continues to make repeat purchases, this may suggest that she/he has some positive evaluations for the brand. It is likely that a stronger attitude and behavior link exists for high familiarity customers than for moderate and low familiarity customers. The relationship between satisfaction and loyalty was found to be stronger among online experienced customers than among online inexperienced customers (Rodgers *et al.*, 2005). It is reasonable to posit that the effect of satisfaction on behavioral intentions is stronger for high familiarity customers than for moderate and low familiarity customers.

The earlier discussion suggests that satisfaction affects post-consumption expectations, which in turn affects behavioral intentions. These effects are likely to be stronger among low familiarity customers as they learn through consumption experience. Having developed relatively weak associations with the brand, post-consumption expectations are expected to continue to play an important role in determining repurchase behavior. However, high familiarity customers with extensive knowledge and experience tend to develop consistent expectations, and it is less likely that a consumption experience would significantly change them. Based on the preceding discussions, the following hypotheses are proposed:

- H5. The effect of satisfaction on repurchase and recommendations differs among high, moderate and low familiarity customers
- H6. The effect of satisfaction on *post-hoc* expectations differs among high, moderate and low familiarity customers
- H7. The effect of *post-hoc* expectations on repurchase and recommendation intentions differs among high, moderate and low familiarity customers

Research population and setting

The study was conducted among Chinese consumers in Hong Kong in the People's Republic of China. Family/popular chains of restaurants which offer table service and extensive menus were chosen for the study. While restaurants possess search qualities such as exterior and interior decoration, they are high in experience qualities in which customers can only evaluate during consumption, such as service delivery, attitudes and manner. Alba and Hutchinson (1987) suggest that an appropriate range of experience should be covered when measuring familiarity. Since the purpose of this study was to assess the impact of familiarity on post-purchase evaluations in a natural setting, the restaurants chosen were at different locations, enabling the study to generate a sample of customers with diverse demographics and levels of familiarity with the restaurant.

Methodology

A longitudinal survey involving pre-purchase measures and post-purchase measures was conducted over a two-month period. The pre-purchase survey measured customer familiarity, ease of making the patronage decision, dining experience, and expectations of various aspects of the restaurant service including food, process, service personnel and environment. The post-purchase survey measured customers' perceptions of the restaurant's performance, satisfaction, *post-hoc* expectations, behavioral intentions and demographic questions. Data were collected from consumers at two points in time, before and after dining at the restaurant. An identical number was used for matching the pre-purchase survey with post-purchase survey.

Pre-purchase measures

The measures used in this study are adapted from a review of the literature. The expectation measure included twenty-five restaurant attributes and one overall item. These attributes were identified in a previous study (Tam, 2005). Participants were asked to indicate the level of service that they would expect to receive from the restaurant on the twenty-five attributes (e.g., "please rate the level of service performance you expect this restaurant will deliver on the attributes"). The scale was 7-point with anchors at 1 "poor" and 7 "excellent". Customer familiarity was a self-reported measure: "How familiar are you with this restaurant with respect to food, service and environment?" (Johnson and Russo, 1984). The 7-point scale was anchored at 1 "not familiar at all" and 7 "very familiar". Familiarity is highly related to experience (Alba and Hutchinson, 1987) and knowledge (Raju *et al.*, 1995). Highly familiar consumers are more knowledgeable, thus they are more confident in making a purchase decision (Raju *et al.*, 1995). As a validity check, the questionnaire included measures on frequency of visits and ease of making the patronage decision.

Post-purchase measures

Customer perceptions of performance were measured using the twenty-five attributes and an overall item on a 7-point scale with anchors at 1 "poor" and 7 "excellent". Disconfirmation and *post-hoc* expectations measures were adapted from Yi and La (2004). Disconfirmation was

measured by asking "How did you feel about the performance of this restaurant?" and "Did you feel that the performance of this restaurant meets your needs?". The 7-point scale was anchored at 1 "worse than I expected" and 7 "better than I expected" with "same as I expected" for the middle point. *Post-hoc* expectations were measured by two absolute and one relative scales. The absolute scale asked respondents to indicate the level of service they would expect this restaurant to deliver in future and the level of service they would expect relative to price. Both were measured on a 7-point scale, anchored by "poor/excellent" and "not worthwhile at all/very worthwhile". The relative scale asked respondents to indicate their expectations of the service relative to the ones prior to consumption on a 7-point scale, which was anchored by "worse than prior expectations/better than prior expectation", with "same as prior expectations" for the middle point. Customer satisfaction was measured with three 7-point scales anchored by "very dissatisfied/very satisfied", "very unpleasant/very pleasant" and "I enjoyed it very much/I did not enjoy it at all". These scales were utilized to capture both the cognitive and the emotional nature of this construct (Hausknecht, 1990). Behavioral intentions were measured by three future purchase intention items and two recommendation intention items. They were measured on a 7-point scale with anchors "definitely will not/definitely will". The post-purchase measures also included demographic questions. The questionnaire was pretested prior to the field survey to assure its clarity and readability.

Data collection

Participants were selected before they entered the restaurants. Personal interviews were used to obtain the pre-purchase responses because interviewers needed to ensure the participants understood the questions and the data collection procedure. Post-purchase evaluations were self-administered. The participants were given the second part of the questionnaire with a return envelope and a cover letter requesting them to complete and return the questionnaire after dining at the restaurant. An incentive was used as a token of appreciation to encourage their participation.

Four interviewers were recruited to conduct the personal interviews. They were marketing graduates of a large university in Hong Kong and all had received formal interview training. A briefing session was held with the interviewers to explain the objective, the questionnaire content and the sampling procedure. This was important to ensure that the selection of the participants and the interviews were conducted in a consistent manner. A total of 505 pre-purchase questionnaires were completed but only 378 participants returned the post-purchase questionnaires, representing a 74.9 percent return rate. T-tests and chi-square analysis were performed, and there was no significant difference in expectations and demographic characteristics between respondents who had returned questionnaires and those who had not. Twelve returned questionnaires were discarded due to many responses missing on key measures or the demographics of the respondents not corresponding to earlier responses. The number of valid responses for analysis was 366.

Sample

The sample consisted of 37 percent males, and 63 percent females. The age of the sample was fairly evenly distributed except in the “18–24” group, which accounted for a slightly higher percentage (22.1), and the “above 50” group, which accounted for a lower percentage (6.8). The median personal monthly income was between \$10,001 and \$15,000, and about 52 percent of participants had attained secondary education. Table I presents the demographic characteristics of the respondents.

Analysis and results

Reliability and validity checks

Familiarity was measured by a single item, and its validity was assessed by how well this measure related to the measures of other constructs to which the construct ‘familiarity’ was theoretically related (Churchill and Iacobucci, 2002). The correlation between experience and familiarity was 0.78 ($p < 0.00$). This supports the contention that familiarity is highly associated with experience, which is consistent with the literature. The sample was split into three groups. Respondents rated 3 or less on the familiarity scale were classified as falling into the low familiarity group, those rated 4 as falling into the moderate familiarity group, and those

rated 5 or above as falling into the high familiarity group. The resultant sizes of the three groups were 153, 108 and 105 respondents respectively. Analysis of variance showed that there was a significant difference in the ease with which restaurant patrons made the decision to dine among the three groups ($F = 34.17$, $p = 0.00$). High familiarity customers on average felt more at ease making that decision than moderate and low familiarity customers ($\bar{x} = 5.65$ v. $\bar{x} = 4.89$ and $\bar{x} = 4.36$). This provides some evidence to support the validity of this measure.

Reliability analyses were performed of the multiple measures, with the Cronbach alpha ranging from 0.87 to 0.94. The perceived performance scale achieved a high reliability of alpha 0.96, expectation (0.95), disconfirmation (0.84), customer satisfaction (0.91), *post-hoc* expectations (0.87), and behavioral intentions (0.94). Confirmatory factor analysis using LISREL was performed to assess the validity of the measures. In order to maintain parsimony in the number of indicators in the model, expectation was measured by the overall item measure and the multi-item measure whereby the responses to the individual expectation attributes were averaged. Similarly, perceived performance was measured by the overall item measure and the multi-item measure whereby the responses to the individual performance attributes were averaged (Hair *et al.*, 1998). Disconfirmation was measured by two indicators, customer satisfaction by three indicators, *post-hoc* expectations by three indicators, and behavioral intentions by five indicators.

Measurement model

The confirmatory factor analysis showed a moderate fit with χ^2 statistic = 330.50 (104 degrees of freedom), GFI = 0.90 and RMSEA = 0.077. The results were closely examined to identify any possible causes of misfit. The standardized residual of covariance between one of the disconfirmation items and the relative *post-hoc* expectation item was 8.22, which was considered very large compared to standardized residuals of covariances among other item (Sharma, 1996). The correlation analysis showed that the relative *post-hoc* expectations item was highly correlated with this disconfirmation item than with the other two *post-hoc* expectations items. Exploratory factor analysis also showed that the relative *post-hoc* expectations item heavily loaded on the disconfirmation factor. Based on these results and the wording of the item, it appears that this item on “customer expectations relative to the ones prior to consumption” was measuring adjusted expectations rather than *post-hoc* expectations, hence it was removed from further analysis. There was no change in the Cronbach alpha for the *post-hoc* expectations scale after this item was removed ($\alpha = 0.87$). The revised measurement model produced a χ^2 statistic = 236.31 (89 degrees of freedom), GFI = 0.93 and RMSEA = 0.067. The results suggest a reasonably good fit. The squared multiple correlations were all met the 0.50 threshold suggested by Fornell and Larcker (1981). The t-statistics showed that the factor loadings were significant (all were greater than 1.96).

Test for metric invariance

Establishment of metric invariance is a logical prerequisite for the structural relations between constructs across groups to be

Table I Demographic characteristics of the respondents

Demographic characteristics	<i>n</i>	%
Sex		
Male	135	36.9
Female	231	63.1
Age		
18–24	81	22.1
25–29	52	14.2
30–34	58	15.8
35–39	51	13.9
40–44	53	14.5
45–49	46	12.6
50 or above	25	6.8
Marital status		
Single	164	45.2
Married	231	53.7
Divorced	4	1.1
Educational attainment		
Primary or below	20	5.5
Secondary	189	51.8
Post-secondary	48	12.1
Tertiary or above	108	29.6
Personal monthly income (HK\$)		
5000 or below	56	16.2
5,001–10,000	102	29.6
10,001–15,000	81	23.5
15,001–20,000	39	11.3
20,001–25,000	21	6.1
25,001–30,000	19	5.5
30,001 or above	27	7.8

compared meaningfully (Steenkamp and Baumgartner, 1998; Yoo, 2002). The equality of metric invariance among the low, moderate and high familiar groups was assessed by multiple sample analysis using LISREL. The covariance matrix was computed separately for each group. Each measurement model was specified as described previously. The full metric invariance was not supported, as the chi-square difference between the nonrestricted model and the full metric invariance model was significant ($\chi^2_{df}(32) = 112.43$, $p < 0.00$). The invariance factor loading was relaxed one at a time, following the recommendations of Steenkamp and Baumgartner (1998) and Byrne (1998). A partial metric invariance model with three factor loadings were relaxed for the moderate familiar group, and three factor loadings were relaxed for the high familiar group. Further relaxing the factor loading did not improve the χ^2 statistic significantly. The fit of the model was better than the full metric invariance model $\chi^2_{df}(6) = 50.9$, $p < 0.00$. The alternative fit indices as suggested by Steenkamp and Baumgartner (1998) have also improved; CFI = 0.97, RESEA = 0.092, CAIC = 1084.44 and NNFI = 0.97. This partial metric invariance was used in subsequent analyses. The results are presented in Table II.

Hypotheses tests

The structural model was specified as in Figure 1, and multiple sample analysis using LISREL was adopted. This technique had the advantage of estimating the multiple and interrelationships whilst accounting for the measurement errors (Hair *et al.*, 1998). Separate covariance matrix, means and standard deviations for the three groups were used as input. The structural estimates were constrained to be equal across three groups and the χ^2 statistic was compared with the χ^2 statistic of the model in which the structural estimates were relaxed. The chi-square difference ($\chi^2_{df}(14) = 31.42$, $p < 0.00$) suggested that the structural estimates were not equal across three groups. Table III presents the results of unconstrained structural estimates and constrained structural estimates.

For the high familiarity group, perceived performance influenced satisfaction, which in turn directly and indirectly influenced behavioral intentions through *post-hoc* expectations. Disconfirmation and prior expectations did not exert significant influence on satisfaction. Unlike for their high familiar counterpart, expectations were found to exert a significant influence on disconfirmation, which in turn influenced satisfaction and, directly and indirectly also influenced behavioral intentions through *post-hoc* expectations for the low familiarity group. For the moderate familiarity group, perceived performance directly affected satisfaction, which in turn directly affected *post-hoc* expectations and indirectly affected behavioral intentions through *post-hoc* expectations.

To assess the hypotheses formally, the methodology adopted was described as follows. An initial baseline model

was estimated by relaxing the structural paths across three groups. A structural estimate was then constrained to be equal across three groups, and the χ^2 statistic of this nested model was compared with the ones of the baseline model. The difference between chi-square statistics for the nested models is itself asymptotically distributed as chi-square, with degrees of freedom equal to the difference in the degrees of freedom for the two models (Steiger *et al.*, 1985). A significant chi-square difference suggested that the structural estimate for the three groups is different. The procedure was repeated until all the structural estimates were assessed. The results showed that three structural estimates were significantly different at the 5 percent level, while one structural estimate was significantly different among the three groups at the 10 percent level. Based on these results, *H1*, *H4* and *H6* were not supported, while *H2*, *H5* and *H7* were supported at the 5 percent level and *H3* was supported at the 10 percent level. Table IV presents the results.

Discussion

This study shows that the effect of perceived performance on disconfirmation, the effect of disconfirmation on satisfaction, and the effect of *post-hoc* expectations on behavioral intentions were stronger for the low familiarity group. Consistent with prior beliefs, the effect of satisfaction on behavioral intentions was stronger for the high familiarity group. There was no difference in the effect of perceived performance on satisfaction, and the effect of satisfaction on *post-hoc* expectations across the three groups.

The rather unexpected result is the effect of expectations on disconfirmation. In the model with all structural estimates unconstrained, negative effects were found for low and moderate familiarity groups, and no significant effect for high familiarity group, yet the chi-square difference test showed that the effect was not significantly different across the three groups. The reason may be that the differences in the effects between low and moderate familiarity groups, and between moderate and high familiarity groups, were small and that they were not found to be significantly different when comparing across three groups.

Managerial implications

Expectations play an important role in satisfaction and repurchase behavior among low familiarity customers. They influence satisfaction through disconfirmation, and strongly determine repurchase and referral behavior. The results confirm Hoch and Deighton's (1989) suggestion that in an unambiguous experience, customers can quickly learn during consumption experience. Although expectations are held with some uncertainty before purchase, customers would learn through the experience and update expectations accordingly. Care should be taken to avoid overly promising customers as a shortfall of expectations can have a great impact on satisfaction and repurchase behavior.

To influence future purchases among low familiarity customers, it may be necessary to deliver services beyond their expectations. It has been stated that this may result in high expectations which make it harder to satisfy customers in the future (Rust and Oliver, 2000). However, understanding

Table II Results of test for metric invariance

	Chi-square	df	CFI	RMSEA	CAIC	NNFI
Full metric invariance	769.50	361	0.96	0.097	1093.83	0.96
Partial metric invariance	718.60	355	0.97	0.092	1084.44	0.97

Table III Parameter estimates of constrained model and unconstrained model

	Constrained model		Low familiar		Unconstrained model		High familiar	
	Betas and gammas invariant Standardized structural coefficients	t- values	Standardized structural coefficients	t- values	Moderate familiar Standardized structural coefficients	t- values	Standardized structural coefficients	t- values
Expectations →								
Disconfirmation	−0.29	−3.77 *	−0.32	−3.53 *	−0.32	−2.67 *	−0.10	−0.54
Perceived performance →								
Disconfirmation	1.06	11.49 *	1.14	10.74 *	1.11	8.63 *	0.82	4.56 *
Disconfirmation →								
Customer satisfaction	0.30	4.10 *	0.38	3.19 *	−0.04	−0.27	0.01	0.04
Perceived performance →								
Customer satisfaction	0.68	8.54 *	0.61	5.02 *	0.99	6.06 *	0.93	6.14 *
Customer satisfaction →								
Post-hoc expectations	0.89	18.70 *	0.91	15.29 *	0.90	12.13 *	0.79	7.92 *
Customer satisfaction →								
Behavioral intentions	0.12	1.11	−0.11	−0.67	0.11	0.57	0.47	3.07 *
Post-hoc expectations →								
Behavioral intentions	0.76	6.47 *	1.00	5.92 *	0.76	3.79 *	0.40	2.53 *

Notes: Completely standardized structural coefficients with t-values; * Structural coefficient is significantly different from zero at 5% level

Table IV Results of Chi-square difference test

	Chi-square difference (df = 2)
Expectations → disconfirmation	0.62
Perceived performance → disconfirmation	8.98 *
Disconfirmation → customer satisfaction	5.36 **
Perceived performance → customer satisfaction	3
Customer satisfaction → post-hoc expectations	0.06
Customer satisfaction → behavioral intentions	10.65 *
Post-hoc expectations → behavioral intentions	11.53 *

Notes: * Significantly different at 5% level; ** Significantly different at 10% level

customers' expectations and finding an opportunity to exceed them is a viable strategy to gain repeat purchases. Firms should always be responsive to customers' needs, and empower staff to incorporate some delightful surprises in their delivery of services to make the consumption experience memorable. In services marketing, people are a crucial element. A warm welcome, and serving with a caring and responsive attitude can make an ordinary service into a unique and memorable experience.

The results of this study reveal that the role of expectations in satisfaction evaluation seems to diminish with experience, and perceptions of performance appear to dominate among high familiarity customers. A plausible explanation is that customers do not actively process expectations when evaluating familiar stimuli such that a small discrepancy between expectations and performance perceptions is not noticed (Oliver, 1989). If there are changes made to the service, customers might need to devote some effort to learn and be familiar with those. It is important that firms conduct

thorough pilot testing to ensure that customers are comfortable with changes.

A high level of familiarity is desirable as it facilitates the purchase decision process, and increases confidence in the purchase. While advertising and public relations can be used to improve familiarity, the most influential source of familiarity is direct experience. Marketers can offer some incentives such as a free trial or coupons to stimulate consumption, and then, during the consumption, educate and familiarize customers with the service while using the opportunity to gain customers' future purchases.

Limitations and future research

This study has several limitations. First, familiarity was measured using a self-reported single item. Ideally, a multi-item scale should be used as a single item scale yields relatively low reliability as documented in the literature. However, there is some evidence to support the contention that the measure used in this study captures what it was intended to measure. It has high face validity, and was highly related to experience. However, it would be desirable to develop a multi-item scale for this construct in future studies. Second, the study was conducted in the context of the restaurant industry, thus generalization of the findings to the other industries may be limited. Future research is needed to see if the familiarity effects on satisfaction evaluation would still hold in a different service setting. Lastly, it has been shown that expectations are dynamic and change during consumption (Hamer *et al.*, 1999). Consequently, customers might not use their prior expectations to assess their satisfaction but the expectations adapted during consumption, thus reducing the effect of prior expectations on satisfaction. It has been suggested that customers might have different types of expectations when making a purchasing decision, evaluating satisfaction and considering

to revisit (Kopalle and Lehmann, 2001). Understanding the type of expectations customers use during the purchase and consumption process is an issue which deserves further investigation.

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Further reading

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Executive summary and implications for managers

This summary has been provided to allow managers and executives a rapid appreciation of the content of the article. Those with a particular interest in the topic covered may then read the article in toto to take advantage of the more comprehensive description of the research undertaken and its results to get the full benefit of the material present.

A couple, regular patrons of a restaurant chain, invite another couple who have never been before to join them for a meal. Evidently the restaurant management has been doing something right, scoring both "word of mouth recommendation" and "repeat purchase" goals.

As each couple sits back, relaxes and anticipates the meal, they are both – probably without being entirely conscious of the fact – involved in a complex process of evaluating the food and drink, the ambiance of the place, the courtesy and friendliness of the staff and, among other things, value for money.

But will these evaluations be working in different ways for each of them? The regulars will already be in a position to anticipate their satisfaction, having had many good experiences there. They will be hoping their friends are equally satisfied. The newcomers' expectations will be somewhat different. Like any new patron of an unfamiliar service offering, they will have their own views of what to expect, no doubt heightened by their friends' glowing reports.

Isn't it likely that disconfirmation theory – whereby comparison of expectations and actual experience are confirmed (if there is a match), negatively disconfirmed (if the perception is lower than the expectation), or positively disconfirmed (if the perception is higher than expectation) – work differently for those who have a pretty good idea of what to expect and those who lack that familiarity and experience?

And what of other diners who have walked into the restaurant for the very first time, without anyone recommending it to them? Maybe they have seen the place advertised, maybe it is part of a chain and they are familiar with the brand, or maybe they are taking a chance on the unknown. Will their evaluation process of the service experience – both the anticipated and actual – differ from those other people's and, if so, how?

As Jackie L.M. Tam asks: "Do customers who are familiar with a brand evaluate their satisfaction with the brand's performance in a similar manner as customers who are not familiar with the brand?"

The study examines the moderating effects of brand familiarity on satisfaction and behavioral intentions, specifically repurchase and recommendation intentions. It also extends the relationship between satisfaction and behavioral intentions to include post-consumption expectations – expectations updated through experience.

It shows that the effect of perceived performance on disconfirmation, the effect of disconfirmation on satisfaction, and the effect of *post-hoc* expectations on behavioral intentions were stronger for the low familiarity group. Consistent with prior beliefs, the effect of satisfaction on behavioral intentions was stronger for the high familiarity group. There was no difference in the effect of perceived performance on

satisfaction, and the effect of satisfaction on *post-hoc* expectations across the groups.

Managers should be aware that expectations play an important role in satisfaction and repurchase behavior among low familiarity customers. They influence satisfaction through disconfirmation, and strongly determine repurchase and referral behavior. Although expectations are held with some uncertainty before purchase, customers would learn through the experience and update expectations accordingly. Care should be taken to avoid overly promising customers as a shortfall of expectations can have a great impact on satisfaction and repurchase behavior.

To influence future purchases among low familiarity customers, it may be necessary to deliver services beyond their expectations even if this could make it harder to satisfy customers in the future. However, understanding customers' expectations and finding an opportunity to exceed them is a viable strategy to gain repeat purchases. Firms should always be responsive to customers' needs, and empower staff to incorporate some delightful surprises in their delivery of services to make the consumption experience memorable. In services marketing, people are a crucial element. A warm welcome, and serving with a caring and responsive attitude

can turn an ordinary service into a unique and memorable one.

The study reveals that the role of expectations in satisfaction evaluation seems to diminish with experience, and perceptions of performance appear to dominate among high familiarity customers. A plausible explanation is that customers do not actively process expectations when evaluating familiar stimuli such that a small discrepancy between expectations and performance perceptions is not noticed. If there are changes made to the service, customers might need to devote some effort to learn and be familiar with those. It is important that firms conduct thorough pilot testing to ensure customers are comfortable with changes.

A high level of familiarity is desirable as it facilitates the purchase decision process, and increases confidence in the purchase. While advertising and public relations can be used to improve familiarity, the most influential source is direct experience. Marketers can offer incentives such as a free trial or coupons and then educate and familiarize customers with the service with a few to future purchases.

(A précis of the article "Brand familiarity: its effects on satisfaction evaluations". Supplied by Marketing Consultants for Emerald.)

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